

Prepared by- ITM alumni Shil & Tony (2023-24)

For more information contact:

jaiswal.shilpa6@gmail.com or

nbrew27@gmail.com

Guide for MSC International Students

1. Accommodation Recommendations and Sources

Finding suitable accommodation is an important aspect of preparing for your international student experience. Here's a comprehensive guide to explore different options and resources;

- **On-campus housing:**

Consider living in on-campus residence halls, student housing, or university-managed housing to be close to campus facilities and academic resources. Apply for on-campus housing through your college's housing office or student services office for a comfortable and supportive living environment.

- **Rental websites and APPs:**

Browse rental websites and platforms and download rental apps such as 28Hse.com, GoHome, Carousell, AsiaXPAT or Rent.com, etc. to search for available rentals, roommates and apartment listings in your desired location.

Use filters to narrow your search by preferences such as budget, location, amenities and type of accommodation, and use app features such as location maps, price filters and messaging functions to communicate with landlords, roommates or owners to arrange viewings or bookings.

- **Apartment forums and groups:**

Join housing forums, Facebook groups or online communities aimed at international students, expats or host country tenants to connect with potential flatmates and share housing tips.

Post your housing requirements, search for flatmates and get advice on accommodation options from fellow students, expats and locals in the community.

- **Roommate placement services:**

Use roommate matching services, roommate finders or roommate search platforms to get in touch with like-minded people, international students or locals looking for a shared apartment.

Fill out roommate profiles, indicate preferences and communicate with potential roommates to discuss living expectations, responsibilities and compatibility before moving in together.

- **Accommodation Checklist:**

Create an accommodation checklist to assess your housing needs, preferences, and priorities, such as location, budget, room size, amenities, proximity to campus, and transportation options.

Evaluate potential housing options based on safety, security, cleanliness, lease terms, utility costs, and landlord communication to ensure a suitable and comfortable living environment

By exploring these housing recommendations and resources, you can find suitable housing options, secure a comfortable living space and create a cozy home away from home during your journey as an international student. Prioritize your housing needs, research thoroughly and seek advice from housing experts to make informed decisions and ensure a positive living experience while studying abroad.

- Some other links related to housing

<https://mp.weixin.qq.com/s/3lzNBu6QlVZG5NG6Cdfikw>

<https://www.facebook.com/share/vjoZX31rXr3mPjk6/?mibextid=K35XfP>

<https://www.28hse.com/en/>

2. Essential Arrangement

- **SIM card:**

Getting a local SIM card is important to stay connected in Hong Kong. You can purchase prepaid SIM cards from various mobile service providers such as CSL, SmarTone, China Unicom (3 Hong Kong) and China Mobile Hong Kong. These SIM cards usually offer data, call minutes and SMS services. You can buy them in stores, shopping centres or directly from the network operator's branches.

Note: Sim card can be brought in any convenience stores like 7eleven, CircleK or Watsons. Buying sim card at airport is costly, for cheaper price you can visit Apliu Street in Sham Shui Po.

https://maps.app.goo.gl/AvVHowpPZephGpc2A?g_st=iw

- **Bank account:**

Opening a bank account in Hong Kong is important for managing your finances. To open a bank account, you will need your passport, proof of address (e.g. a rental contract or utility bill) and sometimes proof of income. Popular banks in Hong Kong are HSBC, Bank of China, Standard Chartered and Hang Seng Bank etc. You can visit a bank branch or open an account online.

- **HKID Application:**

The Hong Kong Identity Card (HKID) is essential for Hong Kong residents. If you plan to stay in Hong Kong for an extended period of time, you must apply for a HKID card from the Immigration Department. To apply, you will need to provide the required documents, including your passport, visa details and proof of address.

Note: Should be applied as soon as possible as the waiting period for appointment is more than 2 months and scan copy needs to be submitted in university.

<https://www.gov.hk/en/residents/immigration/idcard/hkic/bookregidcard.htm>

<https://www.gov.hk/en/apps/immdicbooking2>

- **Octopus Card:**

The Octopus card is a widely used contactless payment card in Hong Kong that you can use for public transportation, shopping, dining and more. As a student, you may be eligible for a Student Octopus Card, which entitles you to discounted fares on public transportation. You can apply for a Student Octopus Card at designated MTR customer service centers by presenting your student ID or proof of enrollment.

Note: Student Octopus card is for the full time students up to age 24, It gives heavy discount in MTR and buses for commutation. And for adult octopus card you can avail the travel subsidiary.

<https://www.octopus.com.hk/en/consumer/octopus-cards/products/on-loan/standard.html>
<https://www.mtr.com.hk/en/customer/main/public-transport-fare-subsidy-scheme.html>

MTR and KMB fare savers are small kiosks located across the city. If one taps one's Octopus card on these, one gets a discount (2\$ for MTR, up to 4\$ for KMB). Details can be accessed here:

https://www.mtr.com.hk/en/customer/tickets/fare_saver.html
<https://www.kmb.hk/faresaver.html>

3. Cultural Adaptation

- **Cultural Adjustment:**

Moving to a new country like Hong Kong may involve a period of cultural adjustment as you have to get used to a different environment, different customs and a different way of life. It is common to experience culture shock, which can manifest itself in disorientation, frustration or homesickness. To cope with the cultural adjustment, it can be helpful to keep an open mind, learn about the local culture and seek support from other expats or locals who can give you advice and insights.

- **Cultural awareness:**

Developing cultural awareness involves understanding and respecting the beliefs, values, traditions and social norms of the local culture in Hong Kong. Familiarizing yourself with Hong Kong cultural practices, etiquette and social customs will help you navigate social interactions, avoid misunderstandings and show respect to the local community. Cultural awareness can help you build positive relationships and integrate better into local society.

- **Language skills:**

The official languages in Hong Kong are Chinese (Cantonese) and English. Although many people in Hong Kong speak English, especially in the cities and in business, knowing some basic Cantonese phrases can be an advantage in your daily interactions with the locals and in building a relationship with them. Improving your language skills through language courses, language exchange programs or language apps can improve your communication skills and help you connect with the community.

Note: Duolingo has a Canto course for Mandarin speakers

Also, Google Home Affairs Department language course. The government teaches it to ethnic minorities

Lastly Google Olivia Canto. It's a very good YouTube channel that can get you started with the basics

- **Social integration:**

Social integration means actively participating in the local community, socializing with locals and building meaningful relationships. To improve your social integration in Hong Kong, you can join social clubs, volunteer organizations, cultural events or sports groups to meet new people and build relationships. Participating in local activities, festivals and gatherings can also give you the opportunity to immerse yourself in the culture and make friends.

4. Health and Wellness

- **Safety Tips:**

Hong Kong is generally considered a safe city, but it is important to practice caution and follow safety tips to ensure your well-being. Some safety tips to keep in mind include:

- Be vigilant of your surroundings, especially in crowded areas and public transport.
- Keep your belongings secure to prevent theft, such as pickpocketing.
- Follow traffic rules and use designated pedestrian crossings when crossing the street.
- In case of emergencies, dial 999 for police, fire, or medical assistance.

- **Mental Health Support:**

Taking care of your mental health is equally important as your physical health. If you are experiencing mental health challenges, stress, anxiety, or depression, seeking professional support is recommended. In Hong Kong, there are mental health services available through public hospitals, clinics, and private counselling centres.

- University offers Counselling & Consultation services which can be accessed here <https://sa.hkbu.edu.hk/cdc/counselling/counselling-and-consultation>

5. Leisure Activities

- **Hiking:**

Hong Kong's diverse landscape offers numerous hiking trails for fitness levels, including popular destinations like Dragon's Back, Lantau Peak, and MacLehose Trail, offering stunning city views and lush greenery.

If you want to start hiking, some beginner level hikes are as follows:

Little Hawaii falls

Kai Shan

Tai Hang Tun Kite Flying Area

Ngong Ping Viewing Point

Dragon's back

Grass Island

Sharp Island

Peng Chau Island

Trio Beach

Ma Tso Lung

Or you can join some meetups group

<https://www.meetup.com/hongkonghikingmeetup/>

- **Beaches:**

With its extensive coastline, Hong Kong boasts several beautiful beaches where you can relax, swim, and soak up the sun. Some popular beaches in Hong Kong include Repulse Bay, Shek O Beach, and Tai Long Wan. These beaches offer facilities such as changing rooms, showers, and water sports equipment rentals.

- **Museums:**

Hong Kong is home to a variety of museums that showcase its rich cultural heritage, history, and art where you can explore exhibitions on topics ranging from ancient civilizations to contemporary art. These museums offer a glimpse into Hong Kong's past, traditions, and artistic achievements, providing a valuable learning experience for history buffs and art enthusiasts.

- **Exhibition Centre:**

There are many exhibitions hosted in Hong Kong convention and exhibition centre, AsiaWorld expo and other venues in Hong Kong like electronics, Dimond & Perl, Education career, Food, etc which can be visited to understand more about trades in Hong Kong.

Note: The following activities are popular here during the summer. If you have time before classes begin, would suggest trying

- Hiking, especially sunset hikes

(Mount High West, Buffalo Hill, Lion Rock)

- Sea kayaking, costs around 100-200HKD (better if you know how to swim, though life jackets are provided anyway)

(Sai Kung, Hoi Ha, Clearwater Bay)

- Boat party, costs around 300-700HKD (involves renting a boat for an entire day, visiting uninhabited islands, paddle boarding, kayaking etc. Again, better if you know how to swim)

- The Ngong Ping cable car is offering 1 free ride on one's birthday provided one has an HKID. Though this ride is worth it even when buying the standard ticket. Also for the information of new students, a number of places in HK offer free stuff on one's birthday, e.g ocean park, sky100 etc. You can google HK birthday offers and pick whatever seems best.

<https://www.np360.com.hk/en/event-promotions/promotions/birthday-offer-for-local-residents>

6. Know your classmate

- **Class Representatives:**

Building relationships with class representatives is crucial for a supportive learning environment. They represent peers' interests, facilitate communication, organize events, and address academic and extracurricular issues. Participate in group activities and class discussions to get to know them better. By fostering positive connections with your classmates, you can form study groups, share knowledge, and collaborate on projects, enhancing your overall academic experience.

- **Other Classmates:**

Take the opportunity to interact with other classmates beyond your immediate circle which will enhance your social network, help make new friends and promote a sense of community within your class. Make it a point to attend school event such as career centre programs, internship programs by faculties and participate in extracurricular activities, and engage in group projects to connect with a diverse range of classmates with varying interests and backgrounds.

7. Student Life at Campus

- **Campus Facilities:**

Getting yourself acquainted with school facilities like libraries, computer labs, learning commons, recreational centres, Pacific coffee, sports, student lounges, and study spaces are crucial for a conducive learning environment, promoting academic success, well-being, and extracurricular activities. Additionally, services like counselling centres, health clinics, and career development offices contribute to the holistic growth and success of students.

- **Clubs, Cultural Organizations, and Student Groups:**

Joining clubs, cultural organizations, and student groups provides students with opportunities to explore interests, develop leadership skills, and connect with peers. These activities foster meaningful activities, friendships, and campus community involvement, promoting personal growth and networking.

Note: If books not available in own library, apply for a JULAC card. You can borrow books from the libraries of a number of universities in HK on it

If you have an HKID, you can search and borrow from public libraries across the city

Google HK 2nd hand book shop. There are a few across the city

- Links for Campus facilities like careers, counselling, scholarships and financial aid, accommodation can be accessed here:

<https://sa.hkbu.edu.hk/>

<https://sa.hkbu.edu.hk/campus-life/support-for-new-students/information-for-international-students/pre-arrival-information>

<https://sa.hkbu.edu.hk/cdc/counselling/counselling-and-consultation>

- HKBU AR Information for Non-local Students (links of Student Services and Supporting Units, information about Hong Kong Identity Card, Student Visa Extension, IANG)

<https://ar.hkbu.edu.hk/tpg-studies/current-students/information-for-non-local-students#:~:text=Non%2Dlocal%20students%20who%20have,visa%20with%20the%20Immigration%20Department.>

- IO (This page is for incoming exchange student, some information may be useful, for example preparing for arrival, during your studies at HKBU, activities @ HKBU, FAQ - Housing & Meals, Fees & Expenses, Health & Insurance, Campus Activities & Facilities, Immigration & Customs Issues, About Hong Kong)

<https://intl.hkbu.edu.hk/student-exchange/incoming-students>

8. Provisional Stores for dietary preference for different nationalities.

• Spices

International students often have a strong connection to the flavors and aromas of their home countries cuisine. Stores such as Traditional Wet Markets, Ethnic Grocery Stores, online retailers and international supermarkets can help students recreate familiar dishes and maintain a connection to their cultural heritage. Offering spices such as Cumin, coriander, prekesse, Turmeric, Chilli peppers and Za'atar etc and others can enable international students to prepare authentic meals that remind them of home. These spices are sold in place like HKTVMall, Amazon, Packnshop, Wellcome and traditional wet market.

• Food:

Due to cultural backgrounds, religious convictions, or personal preferences, international students may be subject to certain dietary preferences. Variety of food goods that suit different diets, such as vegetarian, vegan, halal, kosher, gluten-free, and other alternatives, there are shops that meet these demands, Keeping a variety of fresh vegetables, cereals, meats, dairy products, and specialized goods on hand that overseas students who have dietary preference to have the elements they need to make their favorite meals.

• Others:

In addition to spices and food items, provisional stores can offer other provisions that cater to international students' unique needs and preferences. This may include ready-to-eat meals, snacks, beverages, condiments, cooking oils, and specialty ingredients that are popular in various countries.

• Some provision stores for foreign stuff you might find helpful:

India

Spice Store

<https://www.spicestore.hk>

Bhavika

<https://www.bhavika.online/>

HK Bazaar

<https://hongkongbazaar.com/>

Pakistan

Waqas provision store

<https://goo.gl/maps/BCczAD7rFEehBwqf7> (also has an online store at

<https://waqasprovstore.zobaze.shop/home>)

Pakistan food store (it's also a restaurant)

247 Ki Lung St, Sham Shui Po

Turkish

LetPacific

<https://www.letpacificfood.com/shop/>

Indonesia

Indo Market

<http://www.indomarket.com.hk/shoplists/>

United Kingdom

U Select

<http://www.uselect.com.hk/stockists>

This chain of food stores is generally popular for eggs and cooking oil, which are relatively cheaper here. Also has frozen vegetables and sauces etc.

<https://www.kaibo.com.hk/address.php>

9. Opportunities in HKBU career centre

Students and graduates can explore a variety of career pathways and make connections with potential employers through the Hong Kong Baptist University (HKBU) Career Centre. Students can use the HKBU Career Centre to discover the following recommendations for university jobs, student ambassador, Teaching Assistant for Students with strong academic backgrounds, Research Assistant for students interested in gaining hands-on experience in academic research, Administrative Assistant, career advisor etc.

<https://www.linkedin.com/company/hkbucc/>

10. Weather Arrangement

Hong Kong experiences typhoon season from May to November, with the peak months being July to September. Typhoons are tropical storms that can bring strong winds, heavy rain, and flooding. Students should be aware of the weather arrangements and safety precautions to ensure their well-being. Here are some important points to consider regarding typhoon procedures for international students. Typhoon signals issued by Hong Kong Observatory, University Notification on HKBU Mobile and after typhoon signal.

Note: Arrangement for cancelled lectures and exams are done by the university for any unexpected event of occurrence.

Stock foods such as vegetables, breads, milk, etc as these are likely to be sold out during red alert issued during raining or typhoon season.

Download HK observatory app for HK weather updates.

Hong Kong Observatory: <https://www.hko.gov.hk/en/>

Typhoon Preparedness Guide: <https://www.hko.gov.hk/en/informtc/tcMain.htm>.

11. Recommendations for buying household things.

When it comes to buying household items student can get their household items from Carousell and Taobao which are popular platforms that offer a wide range of products. Students can consider a variety of essential items that are useful for setting up their living spaces. Some common household items to consider buying range from Furniture, Appliances, Kitchenware, Bedding and Linens, Cleaning Supplies and Personal Care Essentials.

Also, if one's ok with buying 2nd hand utensils, people sell those in front of the JHC in Sham Shui Po (location below). The neighbouring 2 streets (Ki Lung and Tai Nan) have a bunch of shops that sell cheap grocery items, cooked food, and sweets etc. from South and SouthEast Asia

<https://goo.gl/maps/7om9B89WQK2uD4ZL6>

12. Internet-based information about Hong Kong (HK) and Hong Kong Baptist University (HKBU)

When searching for internet-based information about Hong Kong (HK) and Hong Kong Baptist University (HKBU), utilizing platforms like YouTube and blogs can provide valuable insights and perspectives.

• YouTube:

Search for videos that offer virtual campus tours of HKBU Campus, Student Vlogs, University Events and Academic Resources, industrial visit etc. Check out the official YouTube channel of HKBU, which may feature promotional videos, interviews with faculty members, and highlights of university achievements.

<https://www.youtube.com/@hongkongbaptistu>

<https://youtu.be/cxepYFa7xIU?si=qp8IEZVI2q-Dznyk>

<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Vp9ZCuiuU7o>

• Blogs:

Search for blogs like student blogs written by current or former HKBU students sharing their experiences, tips, and advice on studying at the university, University Blogs on HKBU website for updates, announcements, and articles about campus events, research projects, and student achievements, Study Abroad Blogs and Travel and Lifestyle Blogs focused on the lifestyle of Hong Kong.

<https://blogs.bath.ac.uk/students/2021/12/01/an-insiders-guide-to-living-and-studying-in-hong-kong-while-on-exchange/>

13. Other important links related to our university and department.

<https://www.facebook.com/share/5fEzG3WwTGZgkN9X/?mibextid=K35XfP>

<https://www.facebook.com/hkbu.comp?mibextid=LQQJ4d>

<https://www.linkedin.com/company/hkbucs/>

<https://www.linkedin.com/school/hong-kong-baptist-university/>

<https://www.linkedin.com/company/hkbucc/>

Student Visa: <https://www.immd.gov.hk/eng/services/visas/study.html>

IANG Visa: <https://www.immd.gov.hk/eng/services/visas/IANG.html>

Job Hunting websites in Hong Kong:

<https://hk.jobsdb.com/>

<https://www.efinancialcareers.hk/>

<https://www.linkedin.com/jobs/>

<https://www.cpjobs.com/hk/>

<https://www.ctgoodjobs.hk/>

Part time work and internship requirements:

<https://www.studyinhongkong.edu.hk/en/hong-kong-education/internship-and-part-time-work.php>